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ARTICLE



Driving Hospitality Frontline Employees' Boundary-spanning Behaviors: A Social Exchange and Role Theory Perspective

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ABSTRACT

The present study explores the antecedents of frontline employees' boundary-spanning behaviors in the hospitality industry. Based on social exchange theory and role theory, a conceptual model was built to explore how three dimensions of perceived organizational support (perceived supervisory support, internal communication, and training) cultivate frontline employees' boundary-spanning behaviors through job satisfaction and organizational commitment. Based on the analysis of 597 hospitality frontline employees in the United States, which were recruited through Amazon Mechanical Turk, this study shows the differential impacts of organizational support types on driving boundary spanning staff to effectively operate on the boundary. Theoretical and practical implications of the findings are articulated.

KEYWORDS

Boundary-spanning behavior; perceived organizational support; frontline employees; hospitality industry

Introduction

The hospitality industry has seen an increasingly popular trend that more and more hotels acknowledge and encourage above and beyond employee behaviors, since delivering high-quality service and generating satisfied customers is fundamental to businesses' success (Madera et al., 2017). Unlike non-service industries and other service settings, the hospitality industry is distinguished by the delivery of an experience that extends beyond the provision of tangible goods during irregular and long hours and thus requires high experiential qualities. Thus, the success of hospitality businesses mainly relies on customer-contact employees' services in creating and delivering high-level, in-person customer service and handling multiple responsibilities simultaneously (e.g., Tsaor & Tang, 2012; Zeithaml et al., 2017).

High-contact frontline employees, as the first and foremost representative of service organizations, are an important nexus between hospitality firms and customers (Yoo & Arnold, 2016; Zablah et al., 2012). Frontline employees not

only create service (Choi et al., 2014), but also represent the organization to outsiders as ambassadors, building up customer relationships (Choi et al., 2014) and advocating the firm's image (Yoo et al., 2014). On the other hand, they also act as "envoys" sharing information internally for improvements in service delivery (Johlke et al., 2002).

Although different types of hospitality businesses may have their own performance scales, frontline employees in this sector generally need to span the firm's boundary by interacting with its external stakeholders in their daily work (Kim et al., 2009). Their behaviors have been encapsulated in the concept of boundary-spanning behaviors, which contribute to products and service excellence through boundary spanning employees' exceeding their job responsibility, promoting the organization's products and service, advocating an outstanding image for the organization, and differentiating from competitors (Bettencourt & Brown, 1997; Yoo et al., 2014). For example, during peak hours in a restaurant, frontline associates may help the customers who are unfamiliar with the menu to order, while acknowledging other customers' time-sensitive needs. On the other hand, the frontline employees may also be in a position to share customers' complaints with the organization to improve the service process and experience in the future. Boundary-spanning behavior is distinct from organizational citizenship behavior because the former highlights a heterogeneous social landscape where employees interact with external stakeholders possibly diverging from the firm's goals, whereas the latter refers to the proactive collaboration and assistance among all types of coworkers, largely within an organization (Williams & Anderson, 1991).

The hospitality industry exhibits a fitting boundary-spanning context where frontline employees engaged with both external and internal environments on the boundary of a firm. Oftentimes facing not only conflicting requests from different parties but also unclear and ambiguous expectations, all while performing as boundary spanners, hospitality frontline employees may easily get stressed due to divergent expectations from organizations and customers, thereby creating cross-boundary issues (Kang et al., 2016; Yang & Lau, 2019). However, studies on how to cultivate boundary-spanning personnel have been limited in hospitality literature until recently (Adam, 2019; Hu et al., 2017; Kim & Qu, 2019; Yang & Lau, 2019).

What factors lead to boundary-spanning behaviors and how to promote such behaviors among frontline employees have aroused interests in the marketing literature (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Wintericht et al., 2013). However, previous research tended to focus on personal motivational factors such as individual differences (i.e., attitude, personality, psychology) (Bettencourt et al., 2001) and contextual variables (i.e., role recognition, symbolization, internalization) (Grant, 2012; Wintericht et al., 2013), neglecting other important organizational supportive factors such as how management interventions can motivate frontline employees' boundary-spanning

behaviors since boundary spanners are likely to be affected by the social environment, especially social support, within the corporation (Bettencourt et al., 2005; Goolsby, 1992; Korschun, 2015).

To address the call for more attention to situational predictors of boundary-spanning behaviors (Malhotra & Ackfeldt, 2016) and sustaining more extra-role service among hospitality employees (Castro-Casal et al., 2019), this research investigates how organizational support predict boundary-spanning behaviors of hospitality frontline employees in the United States. It aims to explain human behavior in a social exchange relationship. For example, when hospitality frontline employees perceive they are getting support or benefits from the organization, they are more likely to reciprocate with positive organizational attitude and behavior (Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005). It provides the basic premise for the current study that frontline employees may devote to more boundary-spanning behaviors when they perceive more organizational support via job satisfaction and organizational commitment.

Literature review and conceptual model

This study is anchored in two theoretical streams: social exchange theory and role theory. According to social exchange theory (Blau, 1964), denoting a two-sided rewarding process between two or more parties (Mitchell et al., 2012; Rasoolimanesh et al., 2015), employees trade commitment and efforts to the organization in exchange for tangible incentives and socio-emotional benefits (Blau, 1964; Eisenberger et al., 1986). Moreover, drawing upon role theory (Walker Jr. et al., 1975), an individual's role is shaped by their perceived support or influences from role senders (supervisors or customers). Presumably, organizational support would prompt boundary spanners to have a clear understanding of their roles and increase their satisfaction and effective performance (Walker Jr. et al., 1975). When employees recognize that they are provided with the support needed, they feel more obliged to meet expectations for work performance. Thus, frontline employees may devote to more boundary-spanning behaviors when they acknowledge job satisfaction and organizational commitment as a result of organizational support. Integrating these two theoretical schools and taking into account the unique characteristics of the hospitality industry, this study intends to the dynamic relationships between three dimensions of perceived organizational support, frontline employees' job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and boundary-spanning behaviors.

Boundary-spanning behaviors

Defining organizations in terms of boundaries between members and non-members, the boundary-spanning theory postulates that boundary spanners

are personnel that engage in social and economic exchanges between an organization and its external environment and ensure the smooth functioning of such interactions (Aldrich & Herker, 1977). Therefore, boundary-spanning behaviors occur through “job-related interactions with a person who is considered part of the environment” and “not a member of the organization” (Robertson, 1995, p. 75). Boundary spanners not only operate within the confines of the firm but interact with external stakeholders whose objectives may diverge from those of the business (Korschun, 2015). As a result, boundary-spanning employees may perceive role stress due to divergent expectations.

Unlike organizational citizenship behaviors that are widely applicable across positions and contexts, boundary-spanning behaviors focus on the unique nature of boundary crossing in organizational functioning (Robertson, 1995). This requires that boundary spanners are not only subject to the expectation of the parent system but also that of a boundary interactive system (Wall & Adams, 1974). That is, boundary-spanning employees not only have the responsibility of presenting products or services in a quality way and fulfilling the organization’s promise through service delivery (Hartline & Ferrell, 1996; Mulki et al., 2012), they also perform value-added functions such as establishing a desirable service environment, extensively communicating with customers, and influencing their preferences toward organizational goals, while crossing the organizational boundary (Manev & Stevenson, 2001; Owen et al., 2015).

Therefore, boundary-spanning behaviors are distinguished, by which customer-organization relationship benefits in terms of the quality of exchange relationships through boundary spanners’ ties (Huang et al., 2016). A key aspect of boundary-spanning behaviors is employees’ interpersonal interaction with the external environment, which is of strategic importance for organizations. Specifically, in the hospitality firms, frontline employees are considered typical boundary-spanners who are constantly involved in transactions with various influencing parties (e.g., supervisors, coworkers, and customers) (Coelho et al., 2011). They not only follow the in-role service procedures but also promote service delivery through interpersonal relationships (Huang et al., 2016), monitoring customer preferences and demands (Peng & Heath, 1996), and introducing innovations to products and services (Manev & Stevenson, 2001). To some extent, the relationship between customers and hospitality organizations is attributed to boundary spanners who are instrumental in bridging communication in consumptive scenarios, resulting in favorable ties and mutual trust between the internal and external environments.

Existing literature suggests that boundary-spanning behaviors manifest in three major dimensions, namely external representation, internal influence, and service delivery (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Bettencourt et al., 2005;

Bowen & Schneider, 1985; Parasuraman et al., 1988; Schneider & Bowen, 1984). Specifically, (1) external representation denotes employees' promotion and advocacy of the organization's products and service to consumers; (2) internal influence happens when employees take initiatives to communicate with the organization and/or colleagues for service improvement; and (3) service delivery refers to providing responsive, courteous, and flexible service to customers. For most frontline employees, external representation and internal influence behaviors tend to be relatively more extra-role whereas service delivery behaviors are more role-prescribed (Bettencourt et al., 2005). Boundary spanning behavior is a significant contributor to hospitality firms' service excellence since it not only provides a mechanism for quality service and settling customers' complaints effectively, but also transmits information about customers' requirements, complaints, and expectations of the service to the firm (Karatepe, 2012).

Given the importance of such behaviors, scholars have been striving to understand the factors that lead to more boundary spanning. A major stream of studies focused on employees' attitudes, personal features, and psychological states as potential triggers of boundary-spanning behaviors (J. Wang et al., 2020; Ying & Norman, 2017; Yoo et al., 2014). Yoo et al. (2014) revealed how bank employees' perception of positive sentiments (i.e., trust, commitment, and satisfaction) motivates them to work, which may spur boundary-spanning behaviors for positive work outcomes. Similarly, service employees who have a strong sense of membership are likely to exhibit boundary-spanning behaviors in the hospitality context (Bayighomog & Arasli, 2019). Nevertheless, few studies in the hospitality context explored the organizational motivators of boundary-spanning behaviors. Presumably, boundary spanners such as sales personnel who perceive being greatly supported by the organization tend to show a high level of job satisfaction (Stamper & Johlke, 2003). As a way to reciprocate perceived organizational support, they may also exhibit higher levels of organizational commitment and more boundary-spanning behaviors (Srivastava & Tang, 2015).

Perceived organizational support

Being apt to face challenges and complexity in their daily work, boundary-spanners are easy suffering stress and exhaustion (Kang & Jang, 2019), which has a significant negative effect on task performance (Cropanzano et al., 2003). Extant research has focused on investigating the impact of personal differences and environmental factors (e.g., person-organization fit) on boundary-spanning behaviors in service settings. Empirical research found that internal undermining (such as supervisor undermining and coworker undermining) in retail banks and insurance companies negatively impacted boundary-spanning employees' service behaviors toward their organizations (Yoo, 2013). On the

contrary, desirable work resources and error-tolerance helps to promote the formation of employees' positive psychological states and well-being, which lead to the successful execution of their work assignments (Schaufeli & Van Rhenen, 2009; X. Wang et al., 2020). Nonetheless, few studies attempt to discover the influence of favorable organizational support on hospitality boundary-spanners' attitudinal and behavioral outcomes.

Perceived organizational support is defined as employees' perception of the extent to which their employers value their contribution and care for their well-being (Eisenberger et al., 1986; Shanock et al., 2012). Usually, it is presented as the employees' perceptions of organizations' commitment toward their employees (Abou Hashish, 2017). Perceived organizational support develops as a result of the social exchange relationship between employees and organizations (Baran et al., 2012). It instills a sense of ownership among the employees, leading to positive performance and attitudes toward the organization (Marchand & Vandenberghe, 2016).

A review of the literature endorsed that a few factors are believed to relate to employees' perceptions of organizational support, such as organizational rewards and work environment (Baran et al., 2012). Employees assess the amount of assistance the organization provides to help them complete assignments, as well as the training and development experiences in areas that are of interest to employees (LaMastro, 2000). Besides, management support, coworker support, supervisor support, learning culture, job design, and job autonomy (Islam & Ahmed, 2018) are evaluated as the environmental factors which are likely to influence employees' attitudinal and behavioral outcomes (Chiaburu et al., 2013). Therefore, in accordance with previous studies (Castro-Casal et al., 2019; Chiaburu et al., 2013; Islam & Ahmed, 2018), organizational support is manifested through perceived supervisory support, internal communication, and training. Supervisory support refers to the level to which employees recognize the support, encouragement, and concerns received from supervisors (Krishnan & Mary, 2012; Rhoades & Eisenberger, 2002). Since the supervisor is the one whom employees contact regularly and with whom they maintain an intimate working relationship, he/she is considered instrumental in pushing frontline employees' organizational commitment (Qureshi & Hamid, 2017) and strengthening their task-related behaviors (Chen & Wang, 2017). Working with a supportive supervisor, boundary spanners' are more receptive to their leader's positive attitude and their work-related motivation and enthusiasm are more likely to be aroused or activated (Chen & Wang, 2017). Supervisory support can lead to job satisfaction of hotel frontline employees (Kang et al., 2015), and employees' affective attachment and organizational commitment (Kang et al., 2015). Hence, this research proposes the following hypotheses:

H1a. Perceived supervisory support positively influences job satisfaction.

H1b. Perceived supervisory support positively influences organizational commitment.

Another relevant aspect of organizational support is internal communication (Hume & Leonard, 2014; Welch, 2012). As a service sector, the hospitality industry relies on effective internal communication among employees to ensure quality service delivery (King & Lee, 2016). Work-related information redundancy may induce a “bystander effect”, which hardly benefits employees’ job involvement (Hussain et al., 2019). High levels of internal communication help solve problems, achieve goals, and benefit service and product innovation, which leads to higher employee satisfaction (Huang et al., 2016). Internal communication also increases employees’ psychological attachment to their organization, as “it encourages employees to perceive themselves as core members of the organization” (Ng et al., 2006, p. 477). Moreover, reinforcing communication channels and valuing external information exchange and sharing help to create a team consensus. According to role theory, effective internal communication would reduce the uncertainties about roles and responsibilities perceived by boundary-spanners and enhance their satisfaction and organizational commitment (Malhotra & Ackfeldt, 2016). Thus, H2a and H2b are formulated.

H2a. Internal communication positively influences job satisfaction.

H2b. Internal communication positively influences organizational commitment.

Last but not least, quality training represents a common means of supporting employees in organizations (Johlke et al., 2002), promoting employees’ positive attitudes and behaviors (Chen, 2017). Training programs are integral to perceived organizational support, promoting employees’ skills, product and customer knowledge, and career development. Both employees and organizations perceive training as an important element for quality assurance, certainly in the case of the hospitality industry (Costen & Salazar, 2011). Meanwhile, training has been linked to greater employee satisfaction, commitment, and positive behaviors, such as role and extra-role performance (Bhat, 2013; Karatepe et al., 2018). Trained boundary spanners are capable of better tying customers and the organization (Huang et al., 2016), gaining a sense of being valued and trusted (Karatepe et al., 2018), and performing work effectively and efficiently (Hanaysha & Tahir, 2016). Empirical study also provided evidence that in the hospitality industry, a high level of training received by frontline employees can affect their extra-role service behavior via affective commitment (Castro-Casal et al., 2019). In comparison to other job benefits, training more likely shows the organization’s willingness to invest in employees,

thereby increasing organizational commitment (Brunetto et al., 2012). Given the above evidence, we arrive at the following hypotheses:

H3a. Training positively influences job satisfaction.

H3b. Training positively influences organizational commitment.

Job satisfaction and organizational commitment

Job satisfaction is conceptualized as a pleasurable emotional state resulting from the assessment of one's job experience (Locke, 1969), which plays a critical role in the mechanism of social exchange theory, performing as a psychological construct mediating the relationship between workplace environment and behaviors (Crede et al., 2007). High levels of job satisfaction are the precursors of many positive outcomes such as organizational commitment (Valaei & Rezaei, 2016) and better performance (Bowling et al., 2015). Adams's (1963) equity theory has been used to help understand job satisfaction and its outcomes (Sean et al., 2015). Simply put, individuals compare their input in work (e.g., effort, knowledge, and skills) with what is gained from such input (e.g., salary, benefits, and intrinsic rewards). Job satisfaction is related to boundary spanning effectiveness (Owen et al., 2015) and used to be measured as a motivator of boundary spanners' performance (Liu et al., 2018; Marrone, 2010). In the hospitality industry, frontline employees' job satisfaction is even more crucial, as an essential contributor to experience quality on the boundary and customer satisfaction (W. G. Kim et al., 2005; Karatepe & Sokmen, 2006).

Organizational commitment indicates the attachment between employees and organizations (Angle & Perry, 1981), implying employees perform in accordance with organizational values or goals (O'Reilly & Chatman, 1986). Employees with high levels of organizational commitment are driven to achieve superior task performance (Huang et al., 2016). In the hospitality industry, both emotional satisfaction and organizational commitment can predict how customer-oriented employees repay the organization and/or represent it to others. Employees who are highly attached to organizations can better handle work stress and make both in-role and extra-role contributions (K. Y. Kim et al., 2016). Based on social exchange relationships such as when employees feel satisfied and committed to their organizations, they tend to reciprocate through supportive attitude and behavior toward the outside audience in a boundary-spanning situation. Moreover, during the process of interpersonal interactions with outside stakeholders, boundary-spanning employees with a higher level of job satisfaction/organizational commitment are typically more involved, acting as ties between the organization and

Perceived organizational support

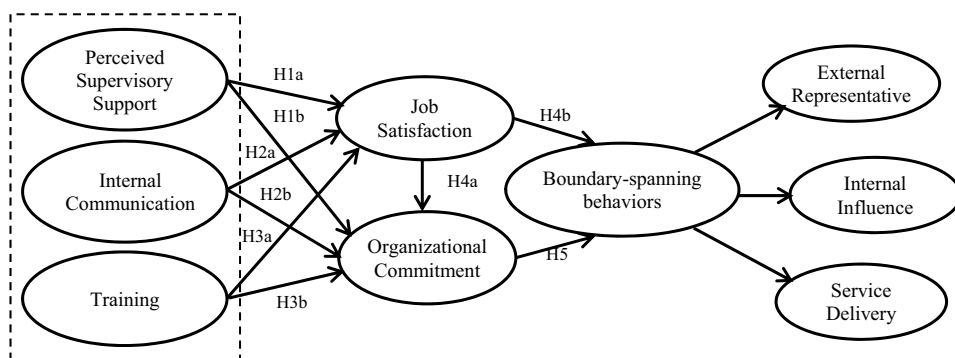


Figure 1. The conceptual model.

customers, rather than simply delivering a service or product (Owen et al., 2015). Therefore, job satisfaction and organizational commitment are considered as predictors of boundary-spanning behaviors, leading to the following hypotheses and conceptual model (see Figure 1):

H4a. Job satisfaction positively influences organizational commitment.

H4b. Job satisfaction positively influences boundary-spanning behaviors.

H5. Organizational commitment positively influences boundary-spanning behaviors.

Methodology

Questionnaire design

The questionnaire was designed as a result of a critical literature review. First, job-related questions (e.g., work context and job position) were asked. Two screening questions were implemented at the beginning of the questionnaire, “Do you work in the hospitality industry (e.g., hotels, restaurants, resorts) in the United States?” and “At work, do you directly interact with guests daily?” to recruit frontline employees in the hospitality industry only. Next, the respondents were directed to describe their perceived organizational support, job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and boundary-spanning behaviors. The survey closed with demographic questions including gender, age, education level, ethnic background, and annual income. The major constructs were assessed with seven-point Likert-type scales from “1 = strongly disagree” to “7 = strongly agree”.

Multi-item indicators from previous studies were employed to operationalize the major constructs. Perceived organizational support consists of perceived supervisory support, internal communication, and training. Perceived supervisory support was measured by a five-item shortened version of Kottke & Sharafinski (1988); internal communication was assessed by a four-item scale from Carrière & Bourque (2009); training was evaluated by three items by Johlke et al. (2002). To evaluate job satisfaction, this study used a scale with five items adapted from W. G. Kim et al. (2005). A four-item scale measuring organizational commitment was developed by Mowday et al. (1979). Lastly, the measurement of boundary-spanning behaviors in this study is based on the conceptual definitions by Bettencourt et al. (2005). Particularly, external representation was assessed by four items, internal influence was measured via four items, and service delivery was tested through five items. The measurement items were adapted to fit the hospitality context and face and content validity were assessed through a panel of academic and industry experts.

Data collection

To evaluate the questionnaire, a pilot test was conducted through Amazon Mechanical Turk in December 2018 and the target population of this study was frontline employees of the hospitality industry who live in the United States. M-Turk was used as data collection tool in this study because it served as an online pool with large and diverse workers completing the required tasks (Paolacci & Chandler, 2014) and proved useful with regard to reaching samples with specific characteristics reliably and validly (Buhrmester et al., 2011).

Among 230 distributed questionnaires, 195 complete questionnaires were usable, for a valid response rate of 84.8%. All dimensions and the total scale showed good internal consistency of the scale with Cronbach's Alphas value from 0.801 to 0.973 (Nunnally, 1978). After making some alterations to the wording of items based on the pilot test, the research team launched the formal survey in January 2019. Participants in the pilot test were excluded from re-taking the survey. Respondents from the worker pool who completed the questionnaires were paid a small honorarium. Out of 680 distributed questionnaires, 83 were excluded due to incompleteness, resulting in a response rate of 87.5%. The large number of sample helps ensure a high level of statistical validity (McQuitty, 2004).

Data analysis

Data were analyzed with the aid of SPSS 25.0 and AMOS 25.0. First, descriptive analysis was performed to offer baseline information of the study constructs. Next, confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was applied to verify the

factorial structure and the reliability and validity of the proposed model. Both first- and second-order models were examined to validate the structure of boundary-spanning behaviors which contain three sub-dimensions (external representative, internal influence, and service delivery). The first-order model is usually used to evaluate the relationship between latent and observed variables (Bollen, 1989), while the second-order model confirms the latent variables and their sub-dimensions (Jarvis et al., 2003). Third, this study performed Harman's single factor test to check whether common method variance was a serious problem. Harman's single factor test is a principal component factor analysis using varimax rotation (Podsakoff & Organ, 1986), suggesting that common method variance is problematic if the result of one latent construct accounting for more than 50% total variance of the measures. The results of this study supported multiple factors with eigenvalues over the cutoff value of one with the first factor representing 22.55% of the variance. In addition, a structural equation modeling (SEM) technique was conducted to assess the hypothesized paths and the associated model fit indexes (Anderson & Gerbing, 1988).

Findings

Sample profile

The sample contains 325 males and 270 females. More than half of the respondents were between the ages of 25–34 (54.94%) and had a white ethnic background (82.07%). Respondents with a 2-year college education are the largest proportion (35.51%). The median of respondents' annual pretax income is 30,000 USD–\$39,999. Respondents represent a variety of job positions across the hospitality industry, including waiter/waitress, bartender, front desk clerk, receptionist, concierge, bellman, housekeeper, cashier, coordinator, supervisor, director, duty/shift manager, and so on. Among them, those working in the front office department (i.e., front desk clerk, receptionist, concierge, bellman, etc.) constitute the largest share (36.68%), followed by the category of waiter/waitress, bartender, and attendant (32.50%). The results showed no critical non-normality with all items' skewness and kurtosis scores below 2, which are under the thresholds of 3 and 10 respectively (Kline, 2015).

Measurement model

The measurement model of 34 items included three sub-dimensions of boundary-spanning behaviors together with job satisfaction and organizational commitment as endogenous constructs and three exogenous constructs (i.e., perceived organizational support, internal communication, and training) was assessed via AMOS 25.0. The first-order model indicated an acceptable fit

($\chi^2 = 1589.698$, $df = 499$, $\chi^2/df = 2.985$, RMSEA = 0.058, GFI = 0.864, AGFI = 0.838, NFI = 0.922, IFI = 0.946, TLI = 0.940, CFI = 0.946), in line with the standard requirements (Byrne, 2010). Table 1 shows that all constructs' standardized regression weights are higher than 0.5 with a significant level at $p < .001$, and the t-value for each factor loading is above the critical score of 1.96 (Hair et al., 2010). Meanwhile, the average variances explained (AVE) of each dimension exceeded 0.50, indicating sufficient convergent validity (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). The lowest composite reliability (CR) of the scales scored at 0.821, beyond the benchmarking of 0.70, showing sufficient internal consistency (Bagozzi & Yi, 1988). Besides, by confirming that the AVE value for each construct is greater than its squared correlations with other constructs, discriminant validity of the scales was achieved (Table 2; Chin, 1998).

Additionally, the second-order factor analysis was applied to examine relationships between the three first-order factors and a second-order factor (boundary-spanning behaviors). Each sub-dimension contributes differently to boundary-spanning behaviors as a holistic construct. The secondary-order factor model yields an acceptable model fit: $\chi^2 = 1536.6$, $df = 502$, $\chi^2/df = 3.061$, $p < .001$, GFI = 0.862, AGFI = 0.836, NFI = 0.919, IFI = 0.944, TLI = 0.937, CFI = 0.944, RMSEA = 0.059. Figure 2 shows the results of the secondary-order model with coefficients between boundary-spanning behaviors and its sub-dimensions, indicating how much variances were shared among the sub-constructs. Results indicate that the external representative shares more variance in boundary-spanning behaviors than the other sub-constructs.

Structural model

The hypothesized paths of the structural model were examined via SEM. The structural path parameters are presented in Figure 3 and Table 3 with standard coefficient estimates. The fit indexes showed that the model had a reasonable fit ($\chi^2 = 1513.08$, $df = 503$, $\chi^2/df = 3.008$, goodness-of-fit index [GFI] = 0.862, AGFI = 0.836, RMSEA = 0.058, NFI = 0.920, RFI = 0.911, IFI = 0.945, TLI = 0.939, CFI = 0.945), in accordance with Byrne (2010).

Perceived supervisory support significantly influenced both job satisfaction ($\beta = 0.51$, $t = 9.908$) and organizational commitment ($\beta = 0.12$, $t = 3.222$). Internal communication influenced both job satisfaction and organizational commitment positively ($\beta_{ICsit} = 0.08$, $t = 1.989$; $\beta_{IC \rightarrow OC} = 0.10$, $t = 2.441$). Also, training affected job satisfaction ($\beta = 0.33$, $t = 5.189$) and organizational commitment positively ($\beta = 0.19$, $t = 4.316$). Overall, the significant and positive coefficients supported H1a, H1b, H2a, H2b, H3a, and H3b, demonstrating the three dimensions of perceived organizational support influenced job satisfaction and organizational commitment.

Table 1. Results of CFA.

		N = 597						
Constructs	Items	SRW	t-value	SMC	AVE	CR		
Perceived Supervisory Support (PSS)	My supervisor cares about my well-being. (PSS1)	0.873	NA	0.761	0.704	0.922		
	If I did the best job possible, my supervisor would be sure to notice. (PSS2)	0.845	27.954***	0.715				
	My supervisor cares about my general satisfaction at work. (PSS3)	0.932	34.436***	0.863				
	My supervisor shows a lot of concern for me. (PSS4)	0.908	32.535***	0.715				
	My supervisor cares about my opinions. (PSS5)	0.892	31.073***	0.761				
Internal Communication (IC)	I know the overall policies and goals of our firm well. (IC1)	0.833	NA	0.693	0.567	0.837		
	I know the information about departmental/group/team plans well. (IC2)	0.800	18.72***	0.640				
	I know my team mates/coworkers well. (IC3)	0.701	17.408***	0.492				
	I know what happens to our firm from internal channels (such as internal e-mails, memos etc.). (IC4)	0.600	13.715***	0.360				
Training (TR)	My firm provides adequate training for new employees. (TR1)	0.805	NA	0.648	0.604	0.821		
	My firm provides adequate ongoing training for employees. (TR2)	0.851	22.67***	0.725				
	The training I have received has helped me to be successful. (TR3)	0.892	23.243***	0.796				
	I consider my job pleasant. (J1)	0.870	NA	0.757	0.628	0.894		
Job Satisfaction (JS)	I feel satisfied with my present job. (JS2)	0.911	32.457***	0.831				
	I definitely like my work. (JS3)	0.926	33.756***	0.857				
	My job is pretty interesting. (JS4)	0.819	26.053***	0.670				
	I find real enjoyment in my work. (JS5)	0.906	31.790***	0.821				
Organizational Commitment (OC)	I find that my values and my firm's values are similar. (OC1)	0.869	NA	0.755	0.740	0.919		
	My firm really inspires the best in me. (OC2)	0.863	27.786***	0.744				
	I really care about the fate of my firm. (OC3)	0.846	25.890***	0.716				
	For me, my firm is a good organization for which to work. (OC4)	0.854	26.654***	0.729				
External Representative (ER)	I always tell outsiders this is a great place to work. (ER1)	0.864	NA	0.747	0.686	0.897		
	I always generate favorable goodwill for our company. (ER2)	0.869	30.425***	0.803				
	I always say good things about our company to others. (ER3)	0.927	32.653***	0.859				
	I always promote our company's products and services. (ER4)	0.796	24.386***	0.633				
Internal Influence (II)	I always make constructive suggestions for service improvement. (II1)	0.787	NA	0.619	0.599	0.857		
	I always contribute many ideas for our product promotions and communications. (II2)	0.785	20.155***	0.616				
	I always share creative solutions to customer problems with other team members. (II3)	0.767	18.711***	0.589				
	I always encourage coworkers to contribute ideas and suggestions for service improvement. (II4)	0.782	18.933***	0.612				
Service Delivery (SD)	I always follow up customer service guidelines with extreme care. (SD1)	0.735	NA	0.540	0.635	0.896		
	I always show responsiveness to my customers. (SD2)	0.853	20.136***	0.728				
	I always show my courteous and respectful to customers regardless of circumstances. (SD3)	0.753	17.496***	0.567				
	I always keep promises to my customers. (SD4)	0.792	18.944***	0.627				
Goodness-of-fit indices for the measurement model	I always show personal attentiveness to my customers. (SD5)	0.797	18.805***	0.635				
χ^2							TLI	CFI
df							0.940	0.946
1589.698								RMSEA
499								0.062

Note: SRW = Standardized regression weights; t-value = critical ratios; NA = not available (regression coefficient is fixed to 1.0); SMC = Squared multiple correlations; AVE = Average variance extracted; CR = Composite reliability.

Table 2. Assessment of discriminant validity.

Constructs	PSS	IC	TR	JS	OC	ER	II	SD
PSS	0.704							
IC	0.334	0.567						
TR	0.582	0.413	0.604					
JS	0.578	0.283	0.510	0.628				
OC	0.648	0.345	0.503	0.517	0.740			
ER	0.462	0.309	0.426	0.605	0.677	0.686		
II	0.300	0.312	0.270	0.319	0.406	0.501	0.599	
SD	0.196	0.094	0.262	0.138	0.195	0.243	0.252	0.635

Job satisfaction had a positive impact on organizational commitment ($\beta = 0.71$, $t = 18.056$); however, it failed to significantly and positively influence boundary-spanning behaviors ($\beta = -0.05$, $t = -0.606$). Also, organizational commitment significantly influenced boundary-spanning behaviors ($\beta = 0.83$, $t = 21.061$). Thus, H4a and H5 were supported, but H4b was not.

Discussion and implications

Discussion

Boundary spanners operate at the boundary or periphery of a service firm, managing communication, negotiating and resolving issues, and advocating the organization's image (Bettencourt et al., 2005). However, hardly any research has examined the antecedents to boundary-spanning behaviors in the hospitality industry, despite it being a highly relevant field. Taking a social exchange and role theory perspective, the current research addresses the gap in the literature by investigating the organizational supportive antecedents and psychological constructs as mechanisms of boundary-spanning behaviors. With most of the hypotheses supported, the results demonstrated that the more organizational support customer-contact employees perceived, the more job satisfaction and organizational commitment they demonstrated which, in turn, led to boundary-spanning behaviors. A closer look at the findings uncovers several valuable insights.

First, all three dimensions of perceived organizational support lead to boundary-spanning behaviors, via job satisfaction and organizational commitment, with varied influences, corroborating the existing findings in the general marketing field that management interventions/supervisor support (Ackfeldt & Wong, 2006), internal communication (Malhotra & Ackfeldt, 2016), and training (Johlke et al., 2002) promote boundary-spanning behaviors of high-contact employees. Overall, such findings harmonize with (1) social exchange theory (Blau, 1964) since employees who perceive organizational support and acknowledge their satisfaction and commitment would reciprocate their

Table 3. Structural path estimates.

Hypotheses	Proposed Structural Model (n = 597)		
	B ^a	t-Value	Result
H1a: PSS→JS	0.51	9.908	Supported
H1b: PSS→OC	0.12	3.222	Supported
H2a: IC→JS	0.08	1.989	Supported
H2b: IC→OC	0.10	2.441	Supported
H3a: TR→JS	0.33	5.189	Supported
H3b: TR→OC	0.19	4.316	Supported
H4a: JS→OC	0.71	18.056	Supported
H4b: JS→BSBs	−0.05	−0.606	Not supported
H5: OC→BSBs	0.83	21.061	Supported

Note: ^a Standardized path coefficient estimates (β) were statistically significant (| t-value | > 1.96 equals to *Sig. < 0.05; | t-value | > 2.58 equals to **Sig.<0.01; | t-value | > 3.29 equals to ***Sig.<0.001).

organizations to maintain a balance in their exchange relationships, and (2) role theory in that boundary-spanners who receive effective organizational support such as clear internal communication tend to become less distressed about their roles and more committed to the job, thereby engaging in both

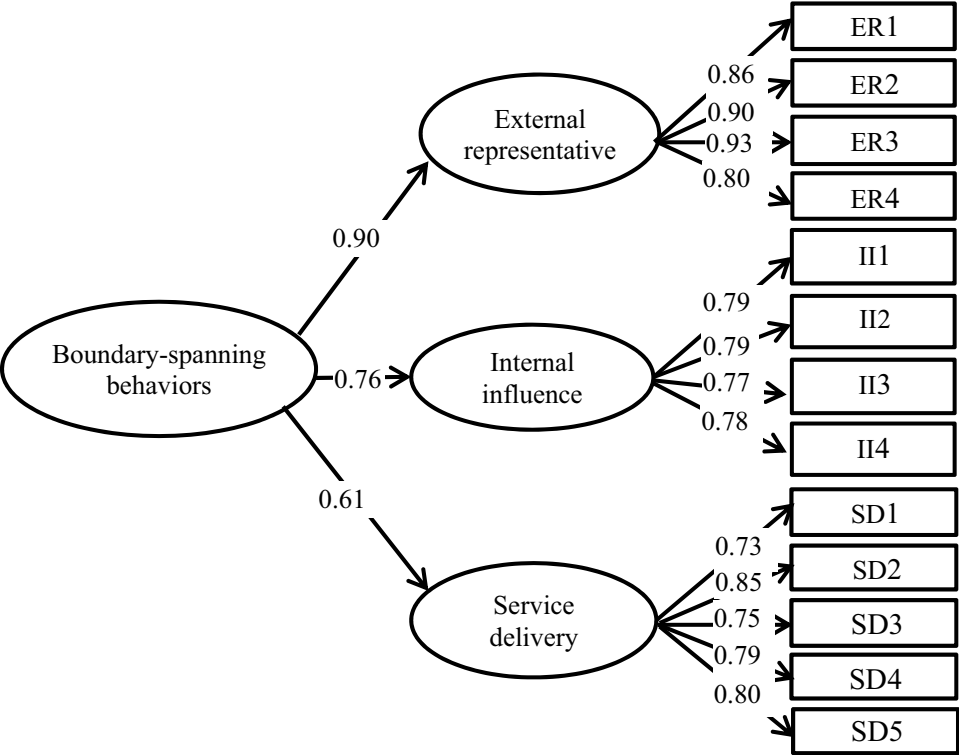


Figure 2. Second-order factor model of boundary-spanning behaviors.

Perceived organizational support

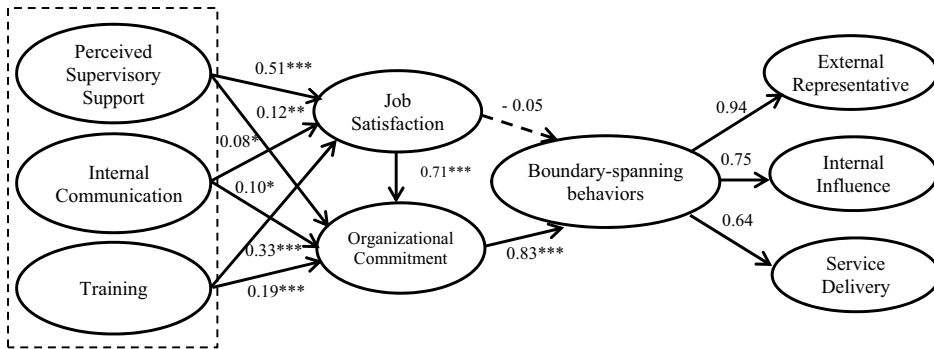


Figure 3. Testing results of structural model.

role-prescribed and extra-role cooperative behaviors (Malhotra & Ackfeldt, 2016).

Second, frontline employees react to the level of perceived support of the organization, supervisor, and coworkers in different degrees. The results of structural equation modeling illustrate that the coefficient between employees' perceived supervisory support and job satisfaction seems stronger than that of internal communication to job satisfaction and that of training to job satisfaction. This converges with Ng & Sorensen (2008) argument that support from the direct supervisor may be seen as particularly valuable, possibly leading to a transformation of working attitudes.

Third, in the case of hospitality frontline employees, this study proved that organizational support leads to a high level of job satisfaction among customer-contact employees and drive them to reciprocate the organizations through high organizational commitment and boundary-spanning behavior, substantiating Wayne et al. (2002). The discovery that the relationship between perceived organizational support and boundary-spanning behaviors is made possible through organizational commitment supports previous findings that (1) affective commitment arises in response to perceived organizational support (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003), and (2) frontline employees on the boundary who are psychologically bound with the organization and identify with its goals tend to execute boundary-spanning jobs more effectively (Malhotra & Ackfeldt, 2016).

Fourth, job satisfaction failed to directly contribute to boundary-spanning behaviors; instead, its effect was made possible only through organizational commitment. Job satisfaction and organizational commitment are often tied together in the literature (Yousef, 2017), with job satisfaction predicting organizational commitment in the hospitality industry (Gunlu et al., 2010; Yao et al., 2019), which is consistent with the current finding. Consistent with Blau (1964, 1968), continued social exchange forming boundary-spanning

behaviors is based on an individual's commitment to the relationship that develops over time from his satisfaction with prior exchanges. Therefore, job satisfaction, a psychological concept, only exerts its influence on the boundary-spanning behavior, through organizational commitment, which is also a behavioral, and a relatively more stable, concept.

Implications

This study offers both theoretical and practical implications. Theoretically, first, this paper contributes to past literature by developing a new conceptual mechanism anchored in social exchange theory and role theory, which considers three distinct forms of organizational support as antecedents to customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. Compared to organizational citizenship behaviors, boundary spanning is a more pertinent concept to the hospitality industry, possessing unique boundary-crossing features such as making both in-role and extra-role contributions to satisfy the expectations of both the parent system and the interactive system. Considering the unique role of boundary spanners, this study advances the research on frontline employees by going beyond the management of distress and burnout and mitigation of unfavorable service encounters (e.g., Adam, 2019; Yang & Lau, 2019), and taking a more proactive stance in creating desired “ambassadors” of the organizations. Second, this study identified differentiated impacts of different organizational supportive dimensions on job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and boundary-spanning behaviors, shedding light on the important role of perceived supervisory support. It informs the literature that support from the direct supervisor is considered as more valuable to frontline employees' job satisfaction, compared to other organizational supportive dimensions. Those who work as boundary spanners and frequently face conflicting expectations seem to value the supervisor's support when assessing the costs and benefits of performing the extra-role, indicating that as a hygiene factor, interpersonal relationship between boundary spanners and their supervisors promote boundary spanners' job satisfaction and their go above and beyond behaviors, which amplifies the insights of the previous research on the outcomes of favorable relationship between supervisor-subordinate (e.g., Major & Morganson, 2011; Tse et al., 2018). Moreover, training presents its relatively stronger contribution to organizational commitment among the three organizational supportive forms. It enriches the literature showing that training is not only critical for in-role performance (e.g., Chen, 2017; Woodside et al., 2020) but also for sustaining affective commitment and extra-role in hospitality firms. Finally, the paper highlights the role of attitudinal constructs between organizational supportive dimensions and boundary-spanning behaviors.

Boundary spanning employees serve as ambassadors in hospitality organizations, resolving issues between the internal and external environment. Meanwhile, they represent a group oftentimes plagued by staff shortage, work overload, irregular work shifts, role stress, and role ambiguity, and then high turnover rate, on the boundary. Therefore, a thorough consideration of frontline employees' work conditions and related hygiene factors, such as clear job descriptions and reasonable hours, need to be given. Since a high level of job satisfaction and organizational commitment lead to frontline employees' boundary-spanning behaviors, it is important to boost employees' satisfaction and commitment so that they want to repay the organizations through positive behavior and/or word-of-mouth to outside audiences.

Moreover, it is of strategic importance for organizations to foster a supportive organizational culture to align boundary-spanning behaviors with managerial goals, encouraging the frontline employees to create and deliver quality service especially when they face role stress and conflicting demands. Hospitality organizations should implement multi-form internal supportive policies and management intervention strategies that elicit a greater sense of belonging and attachment among high contact employees since employees who feel connected to their employer may take extra measures of recommending the organization to others and advocating the organization's offerings. For example, on-the-job training at hospitality firms may not only enable hotel frontline employees to become more competent in completing tasks but also help them to internalize the brand and reinforces their values and behaviors that reflect the brand promise. Such internal branding initiatives make the frontline employees the believers first, and then prompt them to perform boundary-spanning behaviors and deliver excellent service.

Last but not least, hospitality organizations wishing to engage their frontline employees in boundary-spanning behaviors should leverage multi-level supports. The findings showed that support perceived from the direct supervisor is considered more valuable than other aspects. For supporting hospitality high-contact employees who constantly face stressors and conflicting demands, the supervisory support when time is tough is especially precious, such as bringing the manager or supervisor to help high-contact employees to handle demanding customers. To support boundary spanners and promote boundary-spanning behaviors, democratic leadership or participative leadership style should be adopted to recognize, understand and respond to the frontline employees' needs and struggles. Especially, favorable leader behaviors such as charismatic and supportive leadership can evoke positive affect and behaviors among employees. Considering the uniqueness of a hospitality job, supervisors should develop rapport with and show concerns for customer-contact employees' needs especially considering the long and irregular work hours along with the work overload. This can be done by showing willingness

to listen to the employees, expressing compliments and appreciation, or giving them some extra ownership over a task. Besides, to enhance in-role and extra-role behavioral performance in a boundary-spanning customer-contact role, necessary training in different scenarios and quality internal communication should be warranted in hospitality organizations.

Limitations and directions for future research

Several limitations are associated with the current study, which offers suggestions for future research. First, the proposed conceptual framework will benefit from the incorporation of other variables for further exploring the triggering mechanism of boundary-spanning behaviors. Further research can introduce more organizational antecedents into the framework, such as empowerment and social justice. The moderating effect of job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and the mechanism of internal branding in the mechanism are also worth testing. Training and its possible dimensions, considered as a booster for individual development, also deserve further exploration. Second, the research context of this study was the hospitality industry, which is a typical high-contact service environment, but different sectors (lodging, foodservice, tourism, etc.), positions (reservationist, housekeeper, tour guide, etc.), and personality may play a role in the predictive mechanism and thus deserve further exploration. Third, boundary-spanning behaviors could be considered as a protective strategy used by employees to reduce resource depletion at the workplace. Therefore, the conservation of resources theory (Hobfoll, 1989) is worth applying to develop future research. Fourth, this current study was conducted in the United States only; therefore, the respondents' understanding of boundary-spanning behaviors may be influenced by their respective social and cultural contexts. Thus, it is deemed necessary to cross-validate the study findings across different service workforce settings. Also, a mixed-methods study can be designed to refine the mechanism and its associated scales. For example, future studies can conduct interviews with frontline employees to unearth items accounting for job-specific characteristics. Besides, though M-Turk is considered as an effective and valid data collection platform, caution still should be exercised when interpreting the generalizability of the findings. Additionally, the results in this current research are based on self-reported data, which may raise concerns about common method bias, despite the efforts to minimize the threats: (1) the research team informed the respondents of the anonymity of their responses and there was no right or wrong answer to a question, which helped reduce social desirability bias, (2) the researchers adapted the measurements of scales from different empirical studies, removing unclear and ambiguous expressions, and (3) measurements of the predictor and outcome variables were not placed in sequential orders, to reduce estimations of the relationships

(Podsakoff et al., 2012). However, it is recommended to measure the variables at different points in time (Podsakoff et al., 2012). Other research methods such as naturalistic observations or experimental designs should be applied in future research for a better understanding of the dynamics.

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